DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Do Some Righteous Suffer and Others Thrive?

Daat Tevunot §167-168

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §167-168 (section 9, part 2) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 19 October 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

Page 556. Last time we learned that, for the tikkun haklali, evil must be allowed to spread unchecked. Constant reward and punishment would keep it balanced but never reach its root. The root of evil is there for the revelation of God's oneness, and that needs darkness, despair and chaos, as light is appreciated most from the dark. In such times the righteous suffer and must sit it out. Those who accept it with faith are rewarded, and also share in rectifying the world.

§167: the obvious question

The Neshamah asks: if so, all the righteous should suffer. But we see some saddikim doing well and some doing badly.

§168: two ways to rectify

The Sekhel answers. God made evil with its particular boundaries. To eradicate it, He must deal with it according to what it needs. Only God knows the root and the reason for everything He decided. We can know what He wanted; why He wanted it, we cannot ask.

What we do know is that the world is brought to perfection in two ways:

- **Ribui haharah, increasing the light.** Some things are rectified through abundance and goodness: saddikim do good and are rewarded.
- **Miut haharah, reducing the light.** Other things are rectified, on the contrary, through concealment and reduction: saddikim do good and are not rewarded.

Why the world needs both, we do not know. That it needs both, we do. So some righteous people rectify through receiving good, and some through suffering.

The Ramhal says you can see this if you look at the world: nothing happens, good or bad, without some good consequence. As the Gemara says, everything God does is for the good, but in many ways, sometimes through clearly good things and sometimes through apparently bad ones, and this has nothing to do with merit.

The 28 times and the moon

The Ramhal refers to the 28 "times" in Kohelet: "a time to weep and a time to laugh", fourteen on each side.

The Rabbi told a story he had heard that day. Doron Perez, the leader of World Mizrachi, had two sons fighting on Shemini Aseret. One was injured; the other was missing. The injured son's long scheduled wedding took place the day before, and he came to it. They said this is the meaning of the verse: a time to cry and a time to dance, happening at once. Rejoicing at the wedding, and crying that his brother was not there.

Corresponding to these 28 times, the Ramhal says, the sign is the moon, which waxes and wanes. The moon represents the two ways of rectifying the world. That is why the Jewish people are compared to the moon, and why we say they will be renewed like it.

The Rabbi linked this to his daily halachah class, where they have been learning the berakhot in the Rambam. Every berakhah on a natural phenomenon is one line: thunder, lightning, the rainbow, even the berakhah on the sun said once every 28 years. Only Birkat HaLevanah is a whole paragraph, with additions before and after, including mention of David. Why? Because the moon represents human beings. There are 14 days of waxing and 14 of waning, like the 14 pairs in Kohelet. We all have times of rising and times of falling, and over a lifetime we wax and then wane. David's kingdom was great, then gone, and will wax again. One day the moon will be renewed and no longer go through waxing and waning, and so will we.

He tied this to what we learned about the Shekhinah, the manifestation of God's unity in the world. Sometimes it waxes, when good people get good things, and sometimes it wanes, when good people suffer. "Why do you need both? No idea. But you need both."

A participant said that many people are put off faith by seeing such suffering. The Rabbi agreed. One theologian wrote that the greatest obstacle to faith is the chaotic nature of suffering. The next part addresses this as a test.

Who gets which?

On page 560: God divides the two ways of rectification among people according to what is needed, which is so lofty that even the prophets could not understand it. Two equally good people: one rectifies through receiving goodness, the other through suffering. There is no rationale according to their deeds; it is how God divided it. The one who suffered will be compensated.

The Rabbi added an important clarification raised by a participant. We describe person A and person B to make it clear, but in reality each good person probably goes through both at different times of life. And "saddikim" here means good people, as opposed to bad people.

X and Y

A participant put it as a formula. A suffers here: in the world to come he receives X for his deeds and Y as compensation for his suffering. B, equally good, receives X in the world to come, and has already received Y here. The Rabbi accepted this, though he noted that a Y there is worth far more than a Y here; it will all be commensurate. We cannot say the one who suffered has a higher reward for the rectification itself; both are part of it.

X is who you are, your identity. "I don't like the word reward," he said; it means the consequence of being a good person, and that can only be there. Y is like extra pay. Where would you rather have it? He left it as something to think about over the weekend, adding that it is far harder to serve Hashem when you are poor and worried about bills, though wealth can also bring people closer to God.

Mazal, and should a sufferer pray?

This mode, which does not take your actions into account but only what the rectification needs, is what we call mazal. "Mazal tov" means: may you be among the good people who rectify through receiving good.

Should a saddik who suffers not pray for it to stop? "Absolutely not. That's wrong." This mode works alongside the other system, reward and punishment. Am I suffering because of mazal, or because of something I did? Since I cannot know, I pray and ask forgiveness. As another participant noted, you have to put your own life first; the rest is "Hashem's problem". This will be developed in the next part.

Summary

- The world is rectified in two ways: by increasing the light (the righteous rewarded) and by reducing it (the righteous suffering).
- Why both are needed we cannot know, only that they are, like the moon's waxing and waning and Kohelet's "time to weep and time to laugh".
- Which good person rectifies through which is decreed by God, not determined by deeds, and most people experience both.
- Those who suffer are compensated, and their basic reward for who they are is in the world to come.
- This decree is what we call mazal, but because reward and punishment also operate, a sufferer should still pray and repent.

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